

R E V I E W

Core curriculum sport & health city manager. knowledge, skills and competencies serving urban health through sport

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ABSTRACT

Background and aim of the work: Urban health challenges, including demographic ageing, non-communicable chronic diseases, sedentary lifestyles, and growing social inequalities, require innovative professional figures capable of integrating public health, urban planning, sport, and governance. No standardized educational framework currently exists for professionals operating at this intersection. This paper presents the Core Curriculum for the Sport & Health City Manager, an evidence-based educational model designed to define knowledge, competencies, and skills for this emerging professional profile.

Research Design and Methods: the Core Curriculum was developed through a multidisciplinary, participatory, and interinstitutional process coordinated by the Health City Institute, involving Italian universities, scientific societies, public institutions, and sports organizations. Competencies were defined according to the European



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Qualification Framework (EQF) Level 7 standards, integrating medical, epidemiological, urban planning, socio-logical, and managerial expertise through structured expert consultation and evidence synthesis.

Results: the resulting curriculum comprises 11 training modules covering urban health policies, health literacy, active mobility, urban planning, chronic disease prevention, social inclusion, and data governance, delivered over 100 hours with a mixed methodology (40% theoretical, 30% laboratory/simulation, 20% project work, 10% internship). The professional profile is defined by six core competencies oriented toward intersectoral governance, equity, and evidence-based decision-making. **Conclusions:** the Core Curriculum provides a replicable national standard for training Sport & Health City Managers, positioning this figure as a strategic facilitator of urban health governance. Implementation across Italian and European cities may contribute to more integrated, equitable, and health-promoting urban policies through sport. (www.actabiomedica.it)

Key words: urban health, sport, city manager, core curriculum, health governance, physical activity, urban planning

Purpose of the core curriculum

The Core Curriculum for the Sport & Health City Manager was developed with the aim of defining an organic, multidisciplinary educational framework consistent with the social, health, environmental, and urban transformations affecting contemporary cities.

The growth of urban populations, demographic ageing, the spread of non-communicable chronic diseases, sedentary lifestyles, social vulnerabilities, and new territorial inequalities require professionals capable of interpreting health not merely as the absence of disease, but as the outcome of the interaction between the urban environment, quality of life, social inclusion, accessibility to services, and opportunities for physical and sporting activity (1-3).

Within this scenario, the Core Curriculum represents a strategic tool for building a new culture of urban governance oriented toward health and collective well-being. The document establishes shared national educational standards aimed at ensuring consistency, quality, and recognition of the educational pathway throughout the country, in line with European and international guidelines concerning Urban Health, physical activity promotion, and sustainable urban development (4-7).

The Curriculum also identifies the competencies expected to be acquired by professionals at the end of

the educational pathway. These competencies include not only theoretical knowledge in health, urban planning, sports, and social fields, but also the operational and decision-making skills necessary to address the complexity of contemporary urban contexts.

The Sport & Health City Manager must be capable of coordinating diverse institutional actors (8-10), facilitating participatory processes, interpreting epidemiological and territorial data, designing integrated interventions, and promoting evidence-based public policies oriented toward equity and sustainability.

Particular attention is devoted to the definition of measurable learning outcomes, built according to criteria of measurability, applicability, and transferability of competencies (11,12). The educational pathway is not limited to the transmission of theoretical content but aims to develop concrete capabilities in analysis, governance, planning, and evaluation through experiential teaching methodologies, simulations, laboratories, project work, and field activities (9,10,13).

The objective is to ensure that the acquired competencies are effectively applicable within decision-making processes in local administrations, healthcare organizations, sports bodies, and territorial contexts.

The Core Curriculum also defines the levels of professional autonomy characterizing the Sport & Health City Manager role, outlining a figure capable of assuming strategic responsibilities in the design and

management of urban health policies. This autonomy translates into the ability to make complex decisions, coordinate multidisciplinary networks, activate public-private partnerships, and guide urban innovation processes aimed at community well-being.

Alongside professional aspects, the document identifies the structural and organizational requirements of training centers responsible for delivering educational programs. Training quality is considered essential for building a truly effective and recognizable professional profile.

For this reason, training centers must ensure multidisciplinary environments, adequate technological tools, consolidated institutional networks, and a teaching staff capable of integrating expertise from public health, urban planning, sport management, urban sociology, and social policies.

The overall objective of the Core Curriculum is therefore to train an advanced professional figure positioned at Level 7 of the European Qualification Framework (EQF) (11,12), capable of designing, coordinating, implementing, and evaluating integrated urban health policies through sport.

This is an innovative and strategic professional capable of operating as a facilitator of urban governance, a promoter of social inclusion, and an interpreter of the emerging needs of contemporary cities (4-7).

The Sport & Health City Manager must contribute to transforming cities into ecosystems favorable to health, active mobility, participation, and quality of life, promoting an integrated vision in which sport, health, environment, urban planning, and social cohesion become central elements of local public policies (14-17).

Methodology for developing the core curriculum

A Multidisciplinary and participatory pathway among universities, institutions, and experts

The construction of the Core Curriculum for the Sport & Health City Manager is the result of a multidisciplinary, participatory, and interinstitutional methodological process developed with the objective of

creating an innovative, scientifically sound educational model consistent with the transformations affecting contemporary cities.

The definition of the curriculum does not merely represent an academic or technical exercise, but rather a shared process integrating scientific, institutional, professional, and territorial competencies aimed at building a new strategic profile for urban governance in health and sport.

The development process involved universities, research bodies, scientific societies, public institutions, organizations from the sports sector, and professionals from different disciplines, based on the belief that the challenges of urban health cannot be addressed through sectoral or fragmented approaches (14,16,17).

The adopted methodology is founded on the principle of interdisciplinarity, recognizing that health, sport, urban planning, environment, social inclusion, mobility, prevention, and quality of life constitute closely interconnected dimensions.

The scientific coordination of the process was promoted by the Health City Institute, a think tank dedicated to urban health, in collaboration with Italian universities, research centers, and institutional networks engaged in Urban Health, physical activity promotion, and urban sustainability.

The presence of experts from different fields made it possible to integrate medical, epidemiological, urban planning, sociological, economic, sports, and managerial competencies, thereby creating an educational model capable of responding to the complexity of modern cities.

The contribution of the university system

The universities involved represented the scientific and methodological core of the curriculum development process.

Through the contribution of professors, researchers, and professionals from medicine, public health, urban planning, territorial planning, sport sciences, environmental engineering, urban sociology, and public policy, it was possible to define a teaching framework consistent with national and European academic standards.

The involvement of universities made it possible to:

- identify the main emerging educational needs in the relationship between health and cities;
- develop learning outcomes according to the levels of the European Qualification Framework (EQF);
- define measurable and professionally applicable competencies;
- develop innovative and practice-oriented teaching methodologies;
- integrate international scientific evidence with the operational needs of local administrations.

Academic institutions also contributed to defining educational modules, learning levels, and transversal competencies, promoting a balance between theoretical knowledge and practical skills.

In this way, the curriculum was designed not only as an advanced educational pathway but also as an operational tool capable of preparing professionals able to intervene concretely in urban transformation processes.

The role of experts and scientific societies

Alongside the university system, a fundamental role was played by experts from scientific societies, health institutions, local authorities, and sports organizations.

Their contribution enriched the Core Curriculum with practical experiences, case studies, territorial best practices, and professional competencies developed in the field.

The adopted methodology included structured discussion among specialists from different disciplinary sectors, with the aim of:

- identifying the most relevant urban determinants of health;
- defining the operational competencies of the Sport & Health City Manager;
- identifying major organizational and territorial criticalities;

- integrating sport within urban and health policies;
- developing a multilevel governance model oriented toward health.

Scientific societies and experts also contributed to building an evidence-based approach, ensuring that the curriculum was grounded in the most recent scientific evidence concerning prevention, health promotion, active mobility, social inclusion, and salutogenic urban planning (15,18-22).

EQF positioning

The profile is positioned at EQF Level 7 (11,12), corresponding to highly specialized competencies and the ability to manage complex contexts with decision-making autonomy and strategic responsibility.

Professional profile

The Sport & Health City Manager is:

- A strategic coordinator of urban policies for health and sport
- A facilitator of intersectoral governance
- A coordinator of urban determinants of health
- An expert in evidence-based planning
- A promoter of equity and inclusion

Expected learning outcomes

The Core Curriculum for the Sport & Health City Manager was created to respond to the growing complexity of urban health challenges and to integrate into a single professional figure competencies that are currently fragmented across different offices and sectors.

Urbanization profoundly affects health determinants (1,3,23), equity in access to services, and opportunities to engage in physical activity and healthy lifestyles (24-26)

Within this context, there is a need for a professional capable of acting as a bridge between

public health, urban planning, sports policies, and social inclusion.

The educational pathway defined by the curriculum provides interdisciplinary knowledge, operational skills, and decision-making competencies enabling the Sport & Health City Manager to:

1. Act as a driver of urban governance for health and psycho-physical well-being by supporting mayors and administrations in coordinating departments, stakeholders, and communities while developing integrated policies for health and sport.
2. Promote participation and social cohesion in cities and local communities by fostering inclusion, accessibility, reducing inequalities, and involving citizens and schools in adopting healthy lifestyles.
3. Lead territorial projects and interventions aimed at improving citizens' quality of life by activating multisectoral collaborations, monitoring determinants, and ensuring the replicability of solutions across urban territories.
4. Enhance sport as a tool for prevention and improvement of individual and collective health while promoting inclusive and sustainable urban development.
Sport is considered both a health practice and an opportunity for urban regeneration and economic and community growth.
5. Measure impacts and guide institutional decision-making at the local level through data, indicators, and evaluation tools used to assess the effectiveness of implemented policies (27-29)

The structure of the curriculum — aligning objectives, activities, knowledge, competencies, and skills — ensures that the training is oriented toward:

- the ability to work synergistically with all local institutions;
- autonomous decision-making;
- contributing to the design of local policies;
- coordinating territorial networks and partnerships;
- generating measurable benefits for citizens.

In summary, the Core Curriculum trains a professional figure that is:

- innovative, multidisciplinary, and strategic;
- capable of transforming the city into an ecosystem promoting health, inclusion, and sport.

This profile responds to emerging urban health standards in line with the challenges of modern European cities.

Training and professional development of the sport & health city manager

It is considered essential that the design and delivery of university and postgraduate educational activities aimed at training the Sport & Health City Manager include the structured and continuous involvement of professionals operating in urban health, territorial planning, sport, social inclusion, and urban governance.

These professionals represent holders of specific competencies and provide an applied perspective essential for ensuring full alignment between training and the concrete needs of urban contexts and the operational dimension of the role.

Similarly to qualifying educational pathways for strategic professions within the healthcare, sports, and administrative systems, Sport & Health City Manager training courses must be accredited and comply with minimum quality standards concerning educational organization, continuity of training, and the capacity to develop competencies effectively applicable to urban health policies (9-10, 13).

Specifically, these standards must include:

Structural capacity

Availability of environments and spaces suitable for multidisciplinary learning, teamwork, simulation of decision-making processes, and stakeholder coordination.

Infrastructural capacity

Access to digital technologies, territorial-health analysis and monitoring tools, databases, and urban policy evaluation models.

Administrative and organizational capacity

The presence of management and communication processes capable of ensuring educational continuity, integration of multidisciplinary teaching staff, field activities, and partnerships with municipal, healthcare, sports, and university institutions.

These criteria will be specified in a dedicated technical appendix concerning the requirements of training providers.

The teaching methodologies adopted to achieve educational objectives should prioritize an experiential, participatory, and professionalizing approach characterized by practical activities and project work focusing on urban determinants of health, accessibility to sport, intervention planning, and monitoring of social and health impacts (30-34).

The objective is to ensure that the Sport & Health City Manager develops not only theoretical knowledge but above all decision-making, managerial, and governance competencies essential for operating effectively within real Italian and European urban contexts.

The importance of communication in the development of sport & health city manager competencies

Among the core competencies of the Sport & Health City Manager, communication and relational skills play a central role (35-36).

Effective communication, especially within urban contexts where multiple institutional, social, and civic actors interact, cannot rely solely on spontaneity or personal attitudes.

It is therefore necessary for this professional figure to acquire and develop structured communication competencies through specific educational pathways and practical training.

The complexity of urban health and sport policies requires continuous dialogue among administrations, communities, and professionals.

Decision-making processes in a Healthy & Sport City must be transparent, participatory, and informed: citizens are no longer passive recipients but active, informed actors capable of claiming their right to health, well-being, and accessibility to sport.

Effective communication enables the Sport & Health City Manager to:

- create strategic alliances among administrations, sports bodies, health services, schools, and communities;
- facilitate participatory and listening processes concerning territorial needs;
- strengthen citizens' empowerment and shared responsibility in health promotion;
- reduce conflicts, misunderstandings, and opposition during urban transformation processes;
- improve outcomes, effectiveness, and timeliness of sports and health policies.

In summary, effective communication represents a true professional competency of the Sport & Health City Manager, indispensable for ensuring that policies concerning sport and health produce concrete, equitable, and shared results within urban communities.

Core competencies of the sport & health city manager

These are the distinctive characteristics defining the professionalism of the Sport & Health City Manager and differentiating this role from other figures in public health, municipal administration, and sports management (8-10, 37):

1. Governance of urban health and sport
2. Citizen- and community-centered approach
3. Multidisciplinary problem solving and data-driven decision-making
4. Integrated approach to urban health policies
5. Community orientation and equal opportunities
6. Holistic and intersectoral vision of health determinants

Structure of the training program

Duration: 100 hours

ECTS Credits: 20-60 (depending on configuration)

ECM accreditation available for healthcare professionals

Methodology

- 40% theoretical lectures
- 30% laboratories and simulations
- 20% project work
- 10% internship/traineeship

Evaluation

- Intermediate assessments
- Competency evaluation (Bloom rubrics)
- Final project work

Complete grid of training modules

Module 1 – Sport, Health and Urban Policies

OBJECTIVE

Analyze, design, and manage integrated urban policies for health and sport (4-7,38,39) (Table 1).

Module 2 – Health Literacy and Accessibility to Sport

OBJECTIVE

Improve bidirectional communication between citizens and the health/sport system (26,27) (Table 2).

Module 3 – Sport in Schools and Universities

OBJECTIVE

Integrate educational and sports systems to encourage daily physical activity (Table 3).

Module 4 – Healthy Lifestyles in Living and Working Environments

OBJECTIVE

Promote active health and sport within workplaces, communities, and families (24) (Table 4).

Table 1. Training grid for sport, health and Urban Policies

Activities	Knowledge	Competencies	Skills
Analyze the urban context from a health and sport perspective	General	Interpretative	General
Involve citizens in decision-making processes	General	Interpretative	General
Coordinate administrations and stakeholders on health and sport determinants	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Activate public-private partnerships for sport and health policies	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous

Table 2. Training grid for health literacy and sport accessibility.

Activities	Knowledge	Competencies	Skills
Promote training pathways for healthcare and sports professionals	General	Interpretative	General
Facilitate access to information through digital tools	General	Decision-making	Autonomous
Foster alliances among healthcare, schools, and communities	Detailed	Interpretative	General
Create School-Local Health Authority networks for educational guidelines	General	Interpretative	General
Promote sports ethics, inclusion, and fair play	General	Decision-making	Autonomous

Table 3. Training grid for sport integration in schools and universities.

Activities	Knowledge	Competencies	Skills
Strengthen collaboration between the educational and sports systems	Detailed	Interpretative	General
Activate networks among EPS, CUS, ASD, and schools/universities	General	Interpretative	General

Module 5 – Nutritional and Sports Culture

OBJECTIVE

Integrate nutritional education and physical activity as tools for prevention and well-being (40) (Table 5).

Module 6 – Universal Access to Sport

OBJECTIVE

Reduce economic, social, and physical barriers to sports participation (8,41) (Table 6).

Module 7 – Active Mobility & Walkable City

OBJECTIVE

Reduce sedentary lifestyles and pollution through sustainable mobility (Table 7).

Module 8 – Urban Planning for Health

OBJECTIVE

Combine urban planning, climate resilience, and community well-being (14-17, 42-44) (Table 8).

Module 9 – Primary Prevention and Chronic Diseases

OBJECTIVE

Integrate sport and physical activity into care pathways and prevention networks (23-45) (Table 9).

Module 10 – Social Inclusion Through Sport

Objective

Use sport as a driver of equity, social cohesion, and citizenship rights (41) (Table 10).

Table 4. Training grid for healthy lifestyles in living and working environments.

Activities	Knowledge	Competencies	Skills
Activate programs in companies and communities	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Support projects for families and large communities	General	Interpretative	General

Table 5. Training grid for nutritional and sports culture.

Activities	Knowledge	Competencies	Skills
Define personalized nutritional and sports guidelines for target groups	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Organize territorial events and projects (urban gardens, sports museums, etc.)	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous

Table 6. Training grid for universal access to sport.

Activities	Knowledge	Competencies	Skills
Ensure access to sports facilities and green spaces	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Improve the usability of facilities for older adults and active ageing	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Encourage youth participation in sport and counter adolescent dropout	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Promote neighborhood and local sports initiatives	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Plan national and international sports events	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous

Table 7. Training grid for active mobility and walkable cities.

Activities	Knowledge	Competencies	Skills
Develop cycling and pedestrian networks and integrated public transport	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Raise awareness among citizens regarding active mobility choices	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Integrate planning tools (SUMP, monitoring systems)	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous

Table 8. Training grid for healthy-oriented urban planning.

Activities	Knowledge	Competencies	Skills
Limit urban sprawl and enhance historic centers	General	Interpretative	Autonomous
Implement functional and social mix strategies within neighborhoods	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Implement green/blue strategies and UHI mitigation measures	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Develop climate resilience plans	General	Interpretative	Autonomous
Organize intelligent urban waste management systems	Detailed	Decision-making	General

Table 9. Training grid for primary prevention and chronic diseases

Activities	Knowledge	Competencies	Skills
Raise awareness about physical activity in prevention	General	Interpretative	General
Implement prevention projects in living and care environments	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous

Table 10. Training grid for social inclusion through sport.

Activities	Knowledge	Competencies	Skills
Improve conditions in vulnerable neighborhoods through sport	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Ensure universal accessibility to sports facilities	General	Interpretative	General
Promote inclusion for disadvantaged groups	General	Interpretative	General
Support integration pathways for migrant populations	General	Interpretative	General

Table 11. Training grid for monitoring, data governance and sport tourism.

Activities	Knowledge	Competencies	Skills
Activate steering committees and monitoring systems	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Build multi-stakeholder partnerships based on scientific evidence	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Develop urban sports tourism pathways	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous
Interact with the EU/WHO for projects and funding opportunities	Detailed	Decision-making	Autonomous

Module 11 — Monitoring, Data and Sports Tourism

OBJECTIVE

Use data governance and territorial networks to guide decision-making (48,49) (Table 11).

Access requirements

- Master's Degree in relevant fields or Bachelor's Degree + 3 years of documented experience in sports management or local healthcare authorities

Minimum standards for training centers

- Structural capacity (multidisciplinary spaces)
- Infrastructural capacity (databases, monitoring tools)
- Organizational capacity (institutional partnerships)

Career opportunities

- Municipal administrations
- Local health authorities and prevention departments
- Sports organizations
- Third sector organizations

- Urban consultancy
- European project design

Conclusions

The Core Curriculum for the Sport & Health City Manager offers an innovative, evidence-based educational framework, consistent with European national standards and designed to address the growing complexity of urban health challenges. By integrating competencies across public health, urban planning, sport governance, and social inclusion within a single professional profile positioned at EQF Level 7, this curriculum fills a critical gap in current urban health governance systems (3, 10, 81).

The multidisciplinary and participatory development process, combined with a competency-based structure aligned with measurable learning outcomes, ensures both scientific rigor and practical applicability across diverse urban contexts. The eleven training modules provide a replicable and scalable model transferable to different Italian and European settings.

Future research should focus on monitoring the implementation of training programs based on this framework and evaluating their impact on urban health indicators, in order to further strengthen the evidence base supporting this emerging professional figure. Its implementation across national and European urban contexts may contribute to bridging the persistent gap between health promotion strategies and their effective translation into local governance practice.

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